



Excel Interview Q&A

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BASIC LEVEL (1–15)

1. What is Excel?

Answer:

Microsoft Excel is a spreadsheet tool used to:

- Store data in tabular form
- Perform calculations
- Analyze data using formulas & tools

Real-life example:

Managing sales data, calculating profit, tracking attendance.

Interview Tip:

Say:

“Excel is used for data storage, calculation, analysis, and reporting.”

2. What is a Workbook and Worksheet?

Answer:

- **Workbook** → Entire Excel file
- **Worksheet** → Individual sheet inside workbook

Example:

Sales.xlsx → Workbook

Sheet1 → Worksheet

3. What is a Cell and Range?

Answer:

- **Cell** → Intersection of row & column (A1)
- **Range** → Group of cells (A1:A10)

4. What are Rows and Columns?

Answer:

- Rows → Horizontal (1,2,3...)
 - Columns → Vertical (A,B,C...)
-

5. What is a Formula?

Answer:

A formula performs calculations.

Example:

=A1+B1

6. What is a Function?

Answer:

Predefined formula.

Example:

=SUM(A1:A10)

Difference:

- Formula → User-created
 - Function → Built-in
-

7. What are basic Excel functions?

Answer:

- SUM
- AVERAGE
- COUNT
- MIN
- MAX

Example:

=AVERAGE(A1:A10)

8. What is AutoFill?

Answer:

Automatically fills data.

Example:

Drag 1,2 → Excel fills 3,4,5...

9. What is Sorting?

Answer:

Arrange data:

- Ascending
 - Descending
-

10. What is Filtering?

Answer:

Shows only required data.

Example:

Show only Sales > 10,000

11. What is Conditional Formatting?

Answer:

Formats cells based on conditions.

Example:

Highlight sales > 50,000

12. What is Data Validation?

Answer:

Restricts input.

Example:

Dropdown list for Gender

13. What are Freeze Panes?

Answer:

Locks rows/columns.

Example:

Keep header visible while scrolling

14. What is Wrap Text?

Answer:

Displays long text in multiple lines.

15. What is a Chart?

Answer:

Graphical representation of data.

Types:

- Bar
 - Line
 - Pie
-

INTERMEDIATE LEVEL (16–35)

16. What is VLOOKUP?

Answer:

Searches value vertically.

Example:

=VLOOKUP(A2, A1:D10, 2, FALSE)

Use case:

Find employee salary using ID

Limitation:

Searches only left → right

17. What is HLOOKUP?**Answer:**

Searches horizontally.

18. What is XLOOKUP?**Answer:**

Modern lookup function.

Example:

=XLOOKUP(A2, A1:A10, B1:B10)

Advantages:

- Works both directions
 - No column index
-

19. Difference: VLOOKUP vs XLOOKUP

VLOOKUP	XLOOKUP
Old	New
Left to right	Any direction
Index required	No index

20. What is the IF function?**Answer:**

Performs logical test.

Example:

=IF(A1>50, "Pass", "Fail")

21. What is Nested IF?

Answer:

Multiple conditions.

22. What is COUNT, COUNTA, COUNTIF?**Answer:**

- COUNT → Numbers
- COUNTA → Non-empty
- COUNTIF → Condition

Example:

=COUNTIF(A1:A10, ">50")

23. What is SUMIF / SUMIFS?**Answer:**

Conditional sum.

Example:

=SUMIF(A1:A10, ">50", B1:B10)

24. What is a Pivot Table?**Answer:**

Summarizes data.

Example:

Total sales by region

Why important:

- Quick analysis
 - No formulas needed
-

25. What is a Pivot Chart?**Answer:**

Chart based on pivot table.

26. What is Absolute Reference?

Answer:

Fixed reference.

Example:

=A\$1

27. What is Relative Reference?

Answer:

Changes when copied.

28. What is Mixed Reference?

Answer:

Partially fixed.

29. What are Text Functions?

Answer:

- LEFT
- RIGHT
- MID
- LEN

Example:

=LEFT(A1,4)

30. What is CONCAT / TEXTJOIN?

Answer:

Combine text.

31. What is Remove Duplicates?

Answer:

Deletes duplicate values.

32. What is Flash Fill?

Answer:

Auto pattern recognition.

33. What is Named Range?

Answer:

Assign name to range.

34. What is Table in Excel?

Answer:

Structured data format.

35. What is Sparklines?

Answer:

Mini charts inside cells.

ADVANCED LEVEL (36–50)

36. What is the INDEX function?

Answer:

Returns value from position.

Example:

`=INDEX(A1:C10,2,3)`

37. What is the MATCH function?

Answer:

Returns position of value.

38. INDEX + MATCH vs VLOOKUP

Better because:

- Faster
- Flexible
- Works in any direction

39. What is Array Formula?

Answer:

Works on multiple values.

40. What is a Dynamic Array?

Answer:

Spill results automatically.

Example:

`=FILTER(A1:B10, B1:B10>50)`

41. What is a Power Query?

Answer:

Data cleaning tool.

Same concept as Power BI

42. What is Power Pivot?

Answer:

Advanced data modeling.

43. What are Macros?

Answer:

Automation using VBA.

Example:
Automate report generation

44. What is VBA?

Answer:
Programming language in Excel.

45. What is What-if Analysis?

Answer:

- Goal Seek
- Scenario Manager

46. What is Goal Seek?

Answer:
Find input for desired output.

47. What is a Scenario Manager?

Answer:
Compare multiple scenarios.

48. What is a Data Model?

Answer:
Relationship between tables.

49. What is Solver?

Answer:
Optimization tool.

50. What is Dashboard in Excel?

Answer:

Interactive report using:

- Charts
 - Pivot tables
 - Slicers
-

FINAL INTERVIEW STRATEGY

Always explain like this:

1. Definition
 2. Syntax
 3. Example
 4. Use case
-

MOST IMPORTANT TOPICS

- VLOOKUP / XLOOKUP
- Pivot Tables
- IF / SUMIF
- INDEX + MATCH
- Data Cleaning



Power BI Interview Q&A

Power BI Interview Q&A

BASIC LEVEL (1–10)

1. What is Power BI?

Answer:

Microsoft Power BI is a **business intelligence tool** that helps you:

- Connect to different data sources
- Transform raw data
- Build interactive dashboards

Real-life example:

A company has sales data in Excel, SQL, and CRM. Power BI combines all and shows:

- Sales trends
- Top products
- Profit insights

Interview Tip:

Say:

“Power BI is an end-to-end BI tool for data preparation, modeling, and visualization.”

2. What are the components of Power BI?

Answer:

- **Power BI Desktop** → Development tool
- **Power BI Service** → Cloud sharing
- **Power BI Mobile** → Access reports
- **Gateway** → Connect on-premise data

How they work together:

1. Build report in Desktop
2. Publish to Service
3. Share with users

Interview Tip:

Explain flow — *Desktop* → *Service* → *Users*

3. What is Power BI Desktop?

Answer:

A development tool where you:

- Load data
- Transform data (Power Query)
- Create relationships
- Build visuals

Think of it like:

Excel + SQL + Visualization in one tool

4. What is Power BI Service?

Answer:

Cloud platform where:

- Reports are published
- Dashboards are shared
- Data is refreshed automatically

Example:

Manager checks dashboard daily without opening Desktop.

5. Difference between Report and Dashboard?

Answer:

Feature	Report	Dashboard
Pages	Multiple	Single
Data Source	Single dataset	Multiple
Use	Detailed analysis	Summary

Example:

- Report → Full sales analysis
- Dashboard → CEO summary

Interview Trick:

Most people forget: **Dashboard can combine multiple reports**

6. What is Power Query?

Answer:

Power Query is used for **ETL (Extract, Transform, Load)**.

Tasks:

- Remove null values
- Change data types
- Merge tables

Example:

Cleaning messy Excel data before analysis.

Important Concept:

It uses **M Language**

7. What is DAX?

Answer:

DAX (Data Analysis Expressions) is used to:

- Create measures
- Perform calculations

Example:

Total Sales = SUM(Sales[Amount])

Where used:

- KPIs
- Calculations
- Business logic

Interview Tip:

Say:

“DAX works on filter context and row context.”

8. What is a Dataset?

Answer:

A dataset is:

- A collection of tables + relationships + calculations

Example:

Sales table + Customer table + Product table

9. What is a Slicer?

Answer:

A slicer is a **visual filter**.

Example:

User selects:

- Year = 2025
→ All visuals update

Why important:

Improves user interaction

10. What is Data Refresh?

Answer:

Updating data from source.

Types:

- Manual
- Scheduled

Example:

Daily sales update at 9 AM

INTERMEDIATE LEVEL (11–30)

11. What is Data Modeling?

Answer:

Process of creating relationships between tables.

Example:

- Sales table → linked to Product table

Why important:

- Improves performance
 - Enables DAX calculations
-

12. What are Relationships?

Answer:

Connections between tables using keys.

Types:

- One-to-Many (most common)
- Many-to-Many

Example:

Customer → Orders

13. What is Cardinality?

Answer:

Defines relationship type.

Example:

- One customer → Many orders
-

14. What is Star Schema?

Answer:

Best data model design:

- Fact Table → Transactions
- Dimension Tables → Details

Example:

- Fact: Sales
- Dimension: Product, Customer

Why best:

- Fast performance
 - Easy to understand
-

15. What is a Snowflake Schema?**Answer:**

Normalized version of star schema.

Example:

Product → Category → Subcategory

Drawback:

- Complex queries
-

16. Measure vs Calculated Column?**Answer:**

Measure	Calculated Column
Dynamic	Static
Calculated on demand	Stored
Uses filter context	Uses row context

Example:

- Measure → Total Sales
 - Column → Profit per row
-

17. What is Row Context?**Answer:**

Calculation applied **row by row**

Example:

Profit = Sales - Cost

18. What is Filter Context?**Answer:**

Filters applied to calculations.

Example:

Sales for:

- Year = 2025
 - Region = India
-

19. What is CALCULATE?**Answer:**

Changes filter context.

Example:

Sales 2025 = CALCULATE(SUM(Sales[Amount]), Year=2025)

Why important:

Most powerful DAX function

20. What is ALL function?**Answer:**

Removes filters.

Example:

Total Sales All = CALCULATE(SUM(Sales[Amount]), ALL(Sales))

21. What is the RELATED function?**Answer:**

Fetch value from another table.

Example:

Get Product Name in Sales table

22. What is Drill Down?

Answer:

Go deeper into the data hierarchy.

Example:

Year → Month → Day

23. What is Drill Through?

Answer:

Navigate to another page with filtered data.

Example:

Click customer → open details page

24. What is Import Mode?

Answer:

Data stored in Power BI.

Pros:

- Fast

Cons:

- Data size limit
-

25. What is DirectQuery?

Answer:

Live connection to database.

Pros:

- Real-time

Cons:

- Slow performance

26. What is Query Folding?

Answer:

Power BI pushes transformations to source.

Improves performance.

27. What is Gateway?

Answer:

Connects local data to the cloud.

28. What is Aggregation?

Answer:

Summarizing data:

- SUM
 - AVG
 - COUNT
-

29. What is Workspace?

Answer:

Collaboration area in Power BI Service.

30. What is Tile?

Answer:

A pinned visual on the dashboard.

ADVANCED LEVEL (31–50)

31. What is Time Intelligence?

Answer:

Functions for date-based calculations.

Example:

- YTD
 - MTD
 - Previous Year
-

32. What is Incremental Refresh?**Answer:**

Only new data is refreshed.

Example:

Instead of 5 years data → only last 1 day refresh

33. What is a Composite Model?**Answer:**

Combination of:

- Import
 - DirectQuery
-

34. What is RLS?**Answer:**

Row-Level Security restricts data.

Example:

Manager sees only their region

35. What is Performance Optimization?**Answer:**

- Use star schema
- Reduce columns
- Optimize DAX
- Avoid unnecessary visuals

36. What is a Bookmark?

Answer:

Save report state.

Example:

Switch views with button

37. What is Tooltip?

Answer:

Extra info on hover.

38. What is Custom Visual?

Answer:

User-created visuals from the marketplace.

39. What is Dataflow?

Answer:

Reusable ETL layer.

40. What is App in Power BI?

Answer:

Packaged reports shared with users.

41. What is the Deployment Pipeline?

Answer:

Manage environments:

- Dev → Test → Prod
-

42. What is KPI Visual?

Answer:

Shows performance vs target.

43. What is Hierarchy?

Answer:

Organized levels:

- Year → Month → Day
-

44. What is Cross Filtering?

Answer:

Interaction between visuals.

45. What is Bi-directional filtering?

Answer:

Filters both directions between tables.

46. What is a Many-to-Many relationship?

Answer:

Both tables have duplicate keys.

47. What is Data Source Credentials?

Answer:

Authentication for data connection.

48. What is a Scheduled Refresh?

Answer:

Automatic data update at fixed time.

49. What is a Paginated Report?

Answer:

Pixel-perfect printable reports.

50. What is AI Visuals?

Answer:

Smart visuals like:

- Key Influencers
- Decomposition Tree